

1979: Wintel—The Idea

April—June: Microsoft Writes MS-Dos

Microsoft was commissioned to write the operating system for the upcoming model of the IBM PC, since Microsoft was known mainly for their programming languages. Microsoft developed MS-DOS, which was selected by IBM as PC-DOS for their IBM PC.

Prior to that, Tim Paterson wrote 86-DOS, which was 4,000 lines of assembly code, for the computer manufacturer Seattle Computer Products, in 1980. Since it was designed to run on an Intel 8086 processor, it was called 86-DOS. 86-DOS was also known as Quick and Dirty Operating System (QDOS). (Microsoft re-branded 86-DOS as MS-DOS in July 1981.)

More Space!

Seagate Technology was founded by Alan Shugart and Finnis Conner in 1979. Their first product ST-506 was the first 5.25 inch hard disk.

A statement issued by Microsoft about the development of MS-DOS went thus: “DOS addresses only 1MB of RAM because we cannot imagine any applications needing more.”

MS-DOS had a command-line interface along with batch scripting facility through its command interpreter and COMMAND.COM. But it lacked multitasking capabilities.

September: The 68000

Motorola Semiconductor Products designed and sold the Motorola 68000 processor, the 68k family processor. Regarded as a successful 32-bit microprocessor, it resulted from the Motorola Advanced Computer System on Silicon project, which had begun in 1976.

Also in 1979, Intel released its 8088 microprocessor with 16-bit registers and 8-bit external data bus, and could address up to 1 MB memory. It was based on the Intel 8086 and also updated the maximum addressable memory limit by 64 KB, more than theoretical-